

Register for the 2026 IBMer watsonx Challenge

The IBMer watsonx Challenge is back, and this year we're going all in on IBM Bob. The focus is simple: using AI in real work to improve how we get things done.

From July 8 to 22, IBMers will use IBM Bob, with consultants also using IBM Consulting Advantage, to build new capabilities, improve workflows and develop practical ways to work more effectively. Whether you're starting something new or evolving something you're already working on, the challenge is your chance to make Bob your everyday partner.

The challenge begins July 8 at 10:00 a.m. ET.

Visit [#watsonx-challenge-assistance](#) for challenge-related support or questions.

Visit [#bob-and-friends](#) for IBM Bob-related support or questions.

Register today



Single Sign-On

Sign in with your company login.

Sign in

Our Senior Vice Presidents are moving with speed. Are you?

Can't see the video? Watch directly on [IBM Video Streaming](#).

Quick navigation

[Get started ↻](#)

[What's new this year ↻](#)

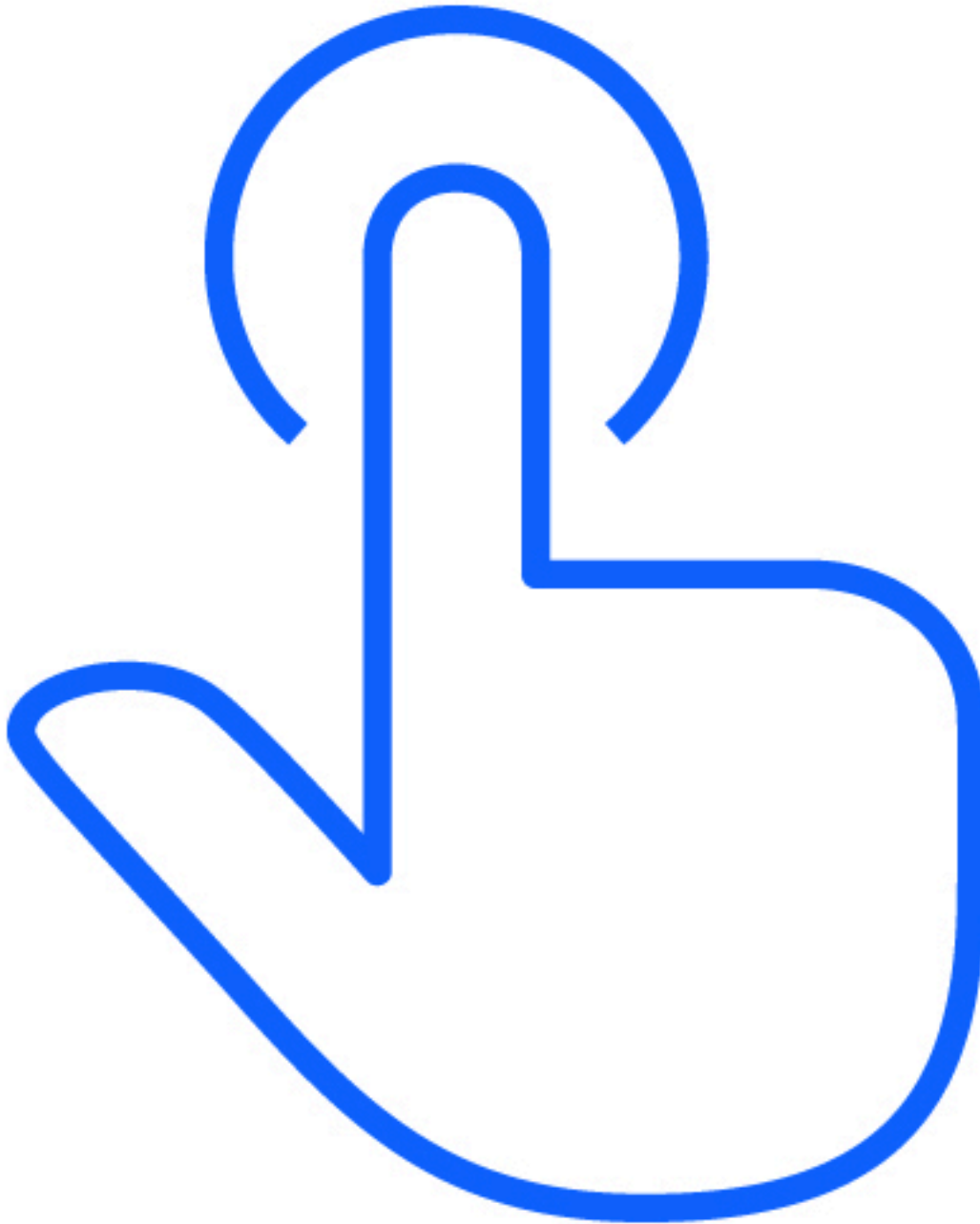
[Timeline ↻](#)

[In-person events ↻](#)

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[Challenge over the years →](#)

Get started now





Step 1

Register and form a team

Registration is now open! After registering, you'll be able to form or find a team using our new AI matching tool. A team can be an individual or include up to 10 participants, and with the personal and team productivity focus this year, you'll likely team with those you work with regularly.

[Register now →](#)

Collapse All ^

Create a team ^

1. Open the **“Create a team”** tab.
2. Enter a team name and click “Create team.” By creating your team, you have been assigned the role of Team Lead, and you will have access to the “Our team” subtab. You can also create and participate as a team of one if you prefer to work independently.
3. In the “Our team” subtab, invite up to 9 IBMers to your team, by:
 - a. Searching for specific IBMers
 - i. Click “Invite members”
 - ii. You can use the “Invite to team” field to enter an email address and invite any IBMer to join your team. You can also use the drop-down filters or the “Filter by name or email” field to narrow down the list of registered participants.
 - iii. Click the “Invite” button next to the name of an IBMer you’d like to invite. They will receive and can accept an email invitation to join your team. If they are not already registered for the challenge, they will need to register before accepting.
 - iv. If your request to invite someone to your team is not accepted, you can continue building your team [here](#).
 - b. Use the AI team matching tool to find teammates
 - i. On the “AI find members” subtab, click the “Get started”

button.

- ii. Enter a matching prompt that describes your team, its needs, your business unit/geography, and any other information you think could help you find the right team members.
- iii. Click “Save my prompt” to submit your prompt.
- iv. Look through potential matches under “Your results.” Click on each to learn more about their skills and invite them to your team. New matches will continue to surface as more people register and look for teams, so check back on the site.

If you have any questions, explore the [FAQs section](#) below or ask in [#watsonx-challenge-assistance](#).

Join an existing team



1. Open the “[Team directory](#)” tab.
2. If you know what team you’d like to join, search for the team by the team name or the team lead's name. If you are just browsing teams, review the AI prompt (if they have entered one) to understand what they are looking for.
3. Once you find a team you want to join, click on the “+” icon for the open position you would like to fill on the team.
4. Write and submit a brief message to the team lead, sharing more about yourself and why you'd like to join. The team lead will receive an email with your request. Once they accept it, you will be added to the team and receive an email confirmation. If your request to join a team is not accepted, you can request to join a different team.

Let AI match you with a team



If you need help finding a team or want to expand your network:

1. On the “[AI team match](#)” tab, click the “Create prompt” button

1. On the [AI team match](#) tab, click the "Create prompt" button.
 2. Tell your fellow IBMers a little bit about yourself! Describe your role, tools you're interested in working with, skills, business unit, geography, and the tools you're interested in working with.
 3. Click "Save my prompt" to submit your prompt.
 4. Look through potential matches under "Your results." Click on each to learn more about their needs and request to join a team. New matches will continue to surface as more teams are created, so check back on the site.
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Step 2

Complete the education

This year's challenge education is designed to support you, whether you're an expert in IBM Bob or just starting. All members of a team must complete the required education* by July 22 at 10 a.m. ET to be eligible to win.

[Required for all IBMers \[~40 mins\] →](#)

[Also required for IBM Consulting \[~1 hr\] →](#)

**Education badges will be available*

Step 3

Sign up for IBM Bob

IBM Bob is at the center of this year's challenge and one of the most important AI tools available to IBMers today. IBMers who receive access to Bob during the challenge will retain that access afterward, allowing you to continue applying what you build and learn to your role.

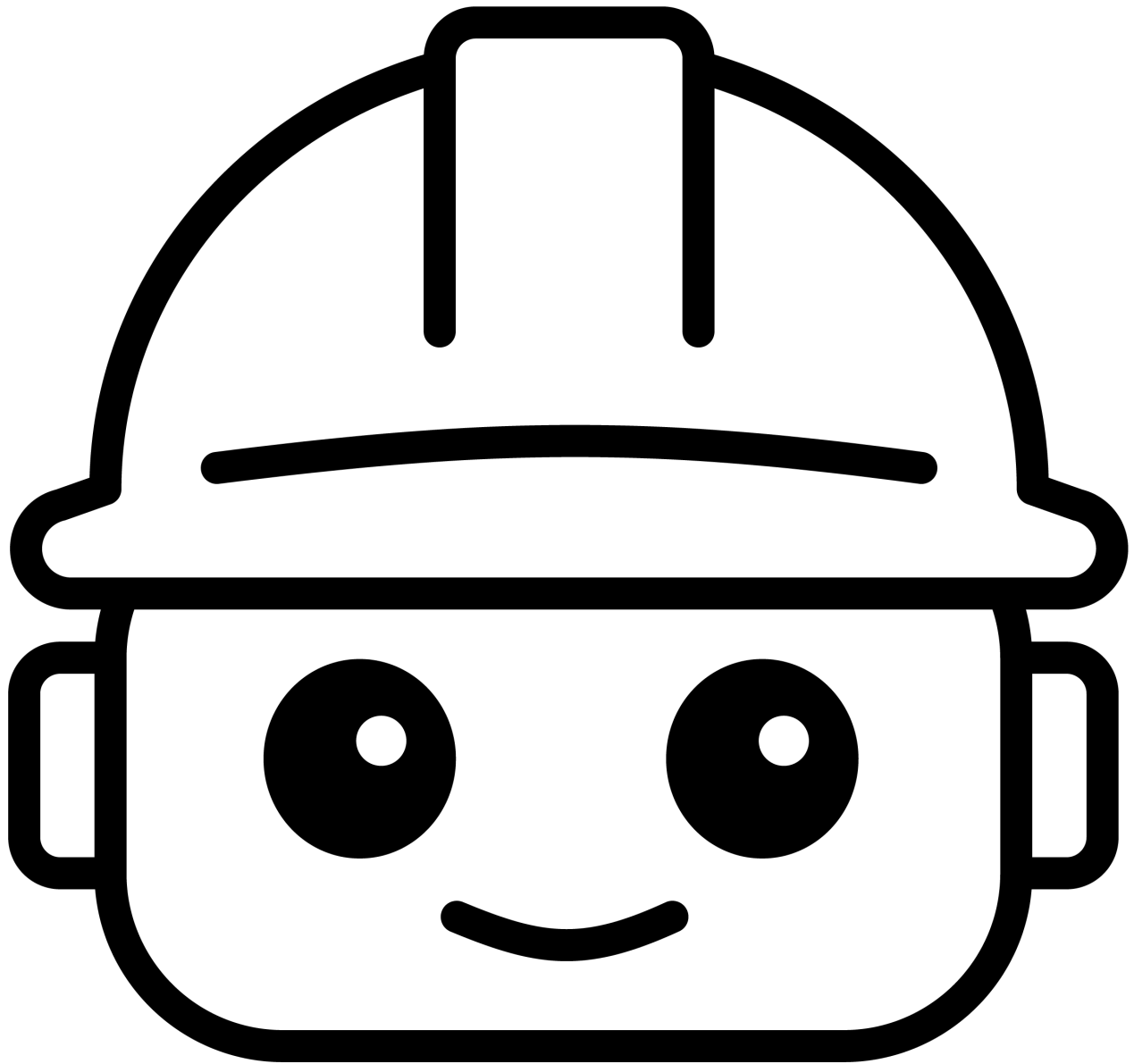
[Request access to Bob →](#)

In-person events coming to 50 IBM locations

Sign up for an event near you ↗

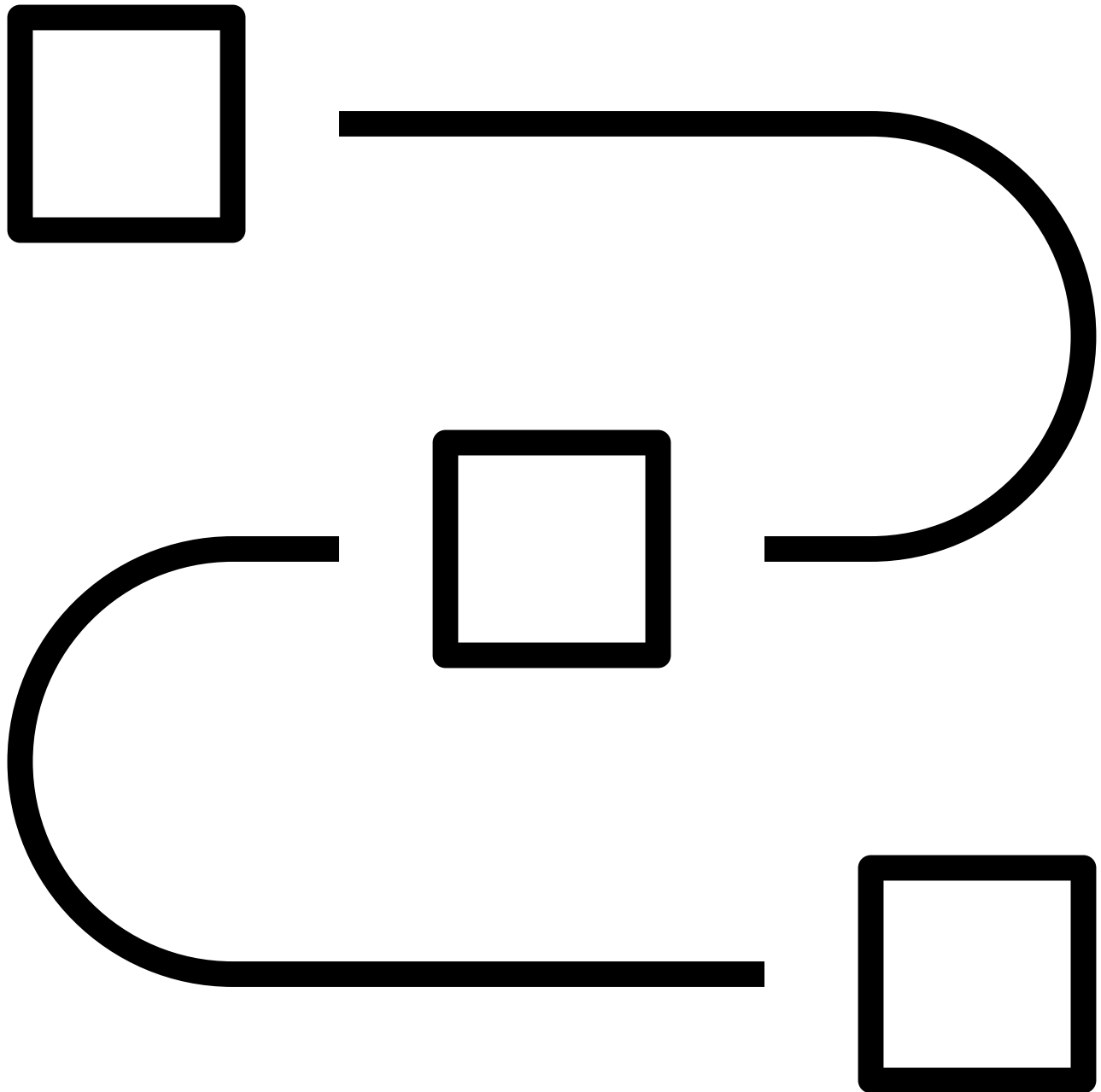


2026 features



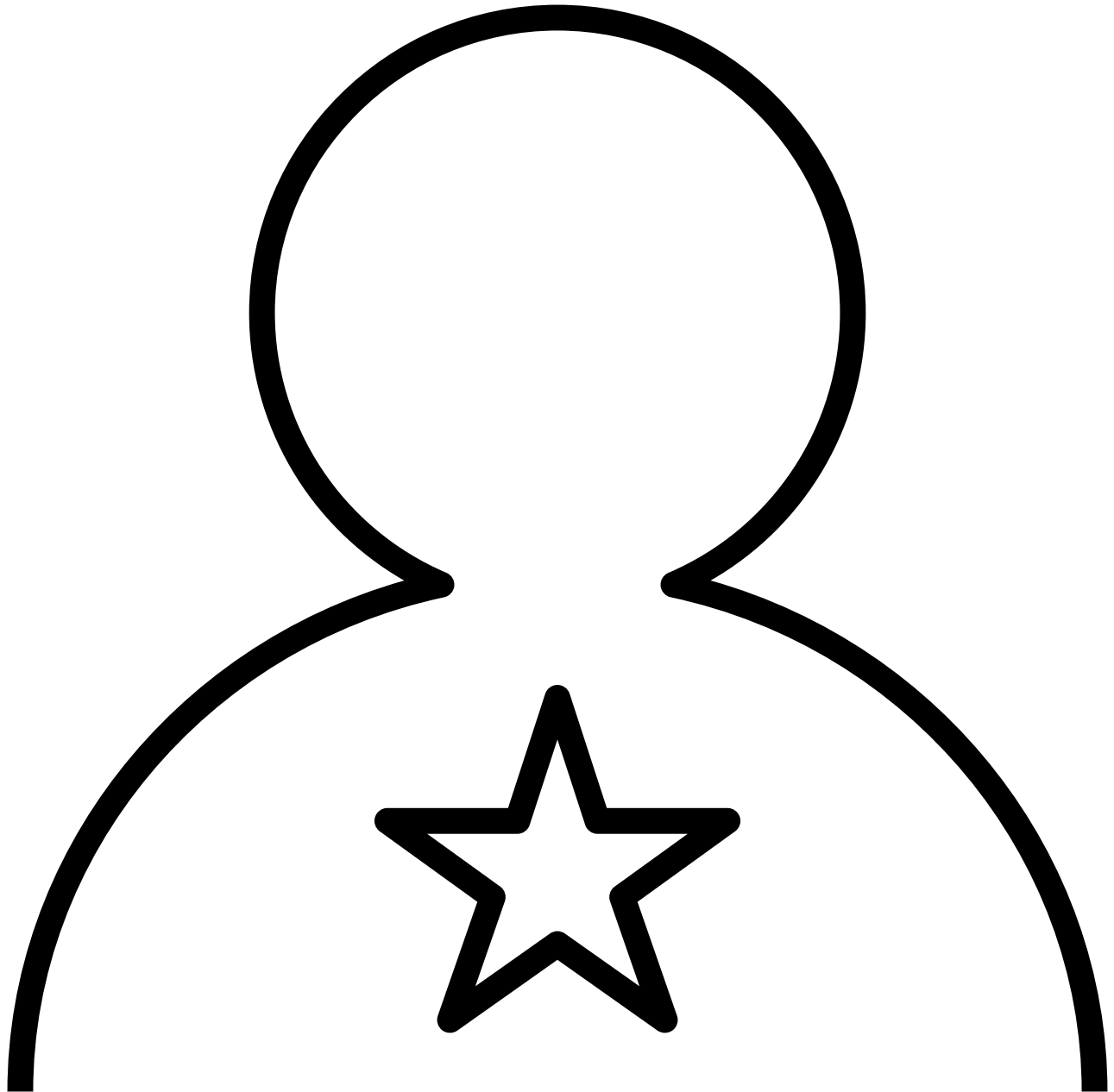
All about Bob

IBM Bob excels in supporting the entire software development lifecycle, but the kinds of work it enables extend far beyond. For non-technical roles—like HR, finance and operations, communications and sales—Bob can assist in juggling multiple tools, coordinating with different teams and keeping work moving smoothly from start to finish.



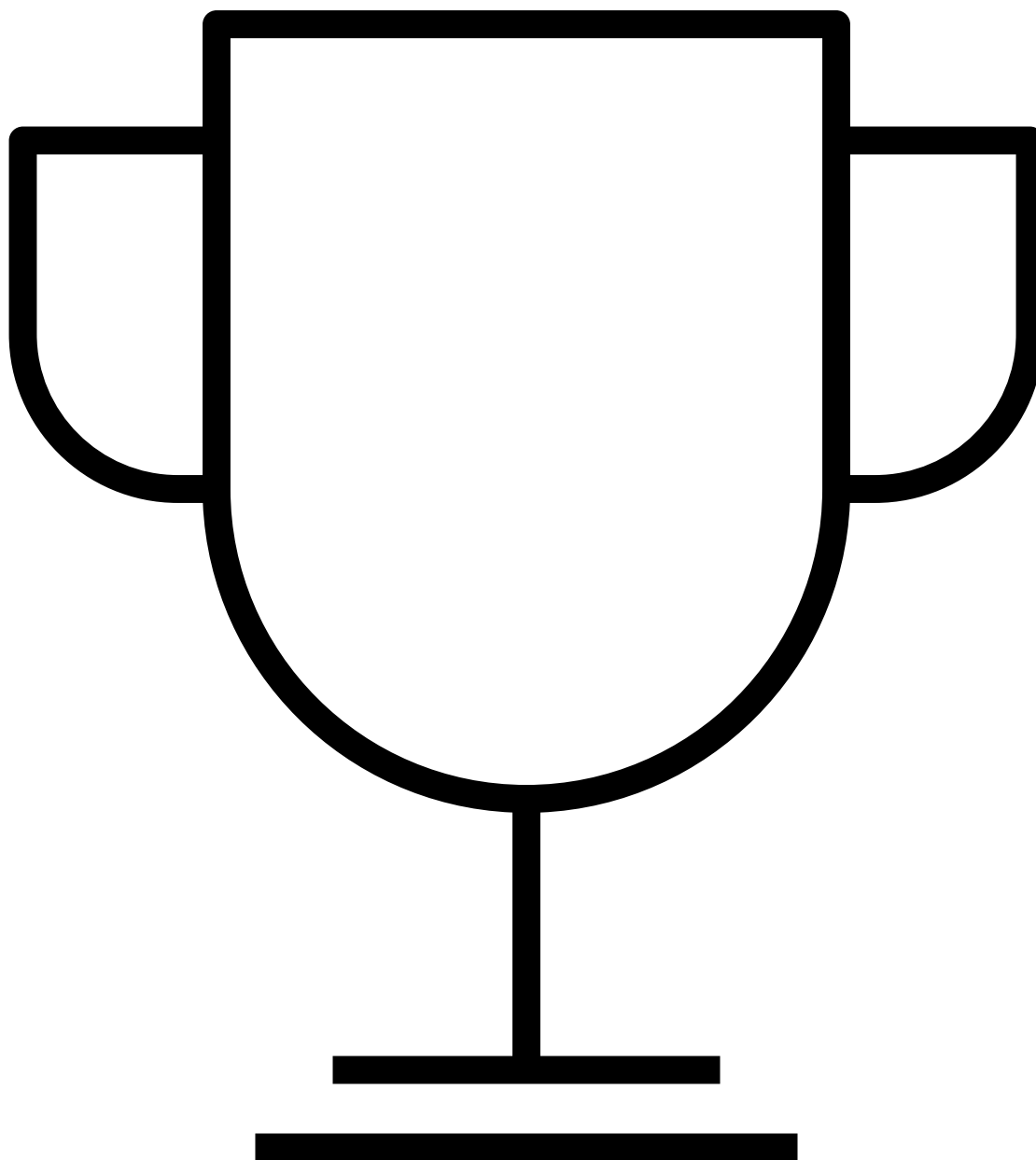
Continued tool access

100,000 IBMers already use Bob internally, and report an average productivity improvement of about 45%. With results like that, we're making a significant investment: every IBMer who receives access to Bob during the challenge will keep it for daily use.



Personal and team productivity

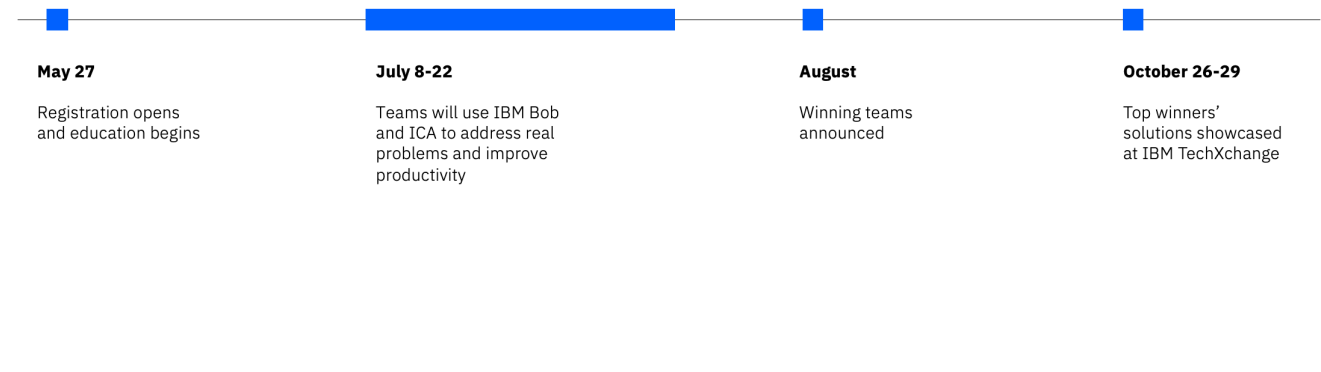
IBMers will use IBM Bob, and consultants will use Bob + IBM Consulting Advantage, to create solutions to their own real productivity problems. You'll likely team with those you work with regularly, focusing on repeatable, ongoing usage that transforms your daily work.



Prizes

Winners will be recognized for demonstrating early results and the long-term productivity potential. In addition to BluePoints, top participants' work will be showcased at IBM TechXchange 2026, demonstrating how Bob quickly delivers tangible business results.

Key dates and timeline



Join an in-person experience

Check the map to see if the IBMer watsonx Challenge in-person experience is coming to your location. Experience IBM Bob through an interactive, forum-style journey and discover how it can improve how work gets done.



Sign up for an event near you

Expand All ▾

Americas	▾
APAC	▾
EMEA	▾
Japan	▾

Note: Additional sites outside of this list may also be hosting events, so keep an eye on your local communications for news on what’s happening in your area.

FAQs

General questions ^

What is the IBMer watsonx Challenge?

The IBMer watsonx Challenge is an annual, company-wide initiative designed to provide IBMers hands-on experience with IBM's leading strategic products through practical application in their day-to-day work. In 2026, the focus is on applying IBM Bob, with consultants using Bob + IBM Consulting Advantage, to build the skills and confidence needed to increase personal and team productivity, and improve how work gets done.

When is the 2026 IBMer watsonx Challenge?

The 2026 IBMer watsonx Challenge will begin July 8 at 10 a.m. ET and end on July 22 at 10 a.m. ET.

What is the time commitment for the IBMer watsonx Challenge?

The challenge runs for two weeks from July 8 to July 22 and is designed to work with your schedules. It can be completed in as little as four hours. But remember, this is your chance to experiment, learn and build the core IBMer skill of AI usage to transform how you work—the more you commit to learning, the more value you'll take into your daily work.

What's different in 2026?

This year's challenge places a stronger emphasis on everyday AI usage, rather than large-scale solution builds. The goal is not to build something that scales across all of IBM, but to use IBM Bob, with consultants also using IBM Consulting Advantage, effectively in real situations you encounter every day and continue using them afterward.

I'm not technical, can I still participate in the IBMer watsonx Challenge?

Yes, the IBMer watsonx Challenge is designed for all IBMers. You do not need to be a developer or have a technical background. The focus of this year's challenge is on improving how you work today using AI tools, not on building new applications. As stated above, while IBM Bob excels in supporting the entire software development lifecycle, the kinds of work it enables extend far beyond IBMers in every role at IBM are already seeing tangible results

beyond. IBMers in every role at IBM are already seeing tangible results working with Bob.

What are the prizes?

BluePoints will be awarded to winning teams from each business area. Top winners featuring Bob will also have the opportunity to have their solutions showcased at IBM TechXchange in Atlanta, Georgia. Additional recognition and opportunities to showcase winning solutions will also be available.

What do I need to submit?

More information on submissions will be available when the challenge begins on July 8 at 10 a.m. ET.

How do I stay informed about the challenge?

All updates will be posted here on the 2026 IBMer watsonx Challenge w3 page, Bob product announcements, including challenge-related updates will be shared in [#bob-announcements](#) on Slack.

Can I use work I've already started?

Yes. You are encouraged to build on existing work, ideas or projects. The challenge is about improving and evolving real work using AI. Just remember, what you submit must be original work that was substantially developed during the challenge between July 8 at 10 a.m. ET and July 22 at 10 a.m. ET.

Will challenge support be available?

Support will be available in the [#watsonx-challenge-assistance](#) Slack channel, where the AI-powered "AskChallenge" assistant will answer your question or connect you to a mentor who can. Response times and depth of support may vary based on demand and the nature of the question.

Registration and eligibility

Who can participate?

- All IBMers are eligible to participate in the challenge. This does not include employees of excluded subsidiaries who are not eligible to receive prizes,

freelancers or independent contractors. IBM clients and partners are not eligible to participate.

- IBM interns are eligible to participate in the challenge, but they will not receive prizes if their internship concludes before prizes are awarded.
- IBM executives are eligible to participate in the challenge individually or as part of a team, however they are not eligible for any prizes.
- If you are eligible for overtime or additional compensation (i.e., weekend premiums), you need to have manager approval prior to participating.

What is required to participate?

To complete the challenge and be eligible for prizes, participants must complete the required education by challenge close on July 22 at 10 a.m. ET. More information about submission requirements will be available when the challenge begins on July 8 at 10 a.m. ET.

How can I sign up?

- To [register](#), log in to the IBMer watsonx Challenge registration site with your w3ID.
- Once logged in, your name and email address will automatically populate.
- You will then be required to accept the Official Rules and Terms and Conditions before clicking the Register button.
- You will receive a confirmation email after you register.

How do I confirm my registration?

After registering, you will receive an email from the IBMer watsonx Challenge team confirming your registration.

How do I remove my registration?

If you choose to remove your [registration](#), you can do so by clicking your name at the top-right and selecting Unregister). But remember, you do not need to be available for the entire length of the challenge to participate.

When does registration end?

Registration is open through July 22 at 10 a.m. ET., the same time submissions are due.

Okay to miss days / take Paid Time Off during the challenge?

Yes. It's okay to miss days or take PTO. The challenge runs over a two-week period by design, so you can participate when it works for you with personal and work commitments.

Teams and team building **How many people can be on a team?**

Teams can consist of anywhere from 1 to 10 IBMers.

Can I participate on my own?

Yes. Individual participation is fully supported. Just be sure to create your team of one to be able to submit to the challenge once it starts.

What is the recommended team size?

Teams can consist of anywhere from 1 to 10 IBMers and be successful at any size. Given the personal and team productivity focus of the 2026 challenge and the focus on individual AI tool usage, teams may be smaller than in years past. You should consider the problem you want to solve as well as the people you typically collaborate with on that problem to determine a team size that works best for you.

How do I create a team?

After registering for the challenge, you can create a team by entering a team name and selecting "Create team." The person who creates the team becomes the team lead. You can invite specific IBMers to join or use the AI-assisted team-matching tool to find teammates with relevant interests and skills. Teams can include 1 to 10 IBMers.

How do I join an existing team?

To join a team, go to the challenge page and select "Team Directory." Search by team name, click "Request to join", and submit a short message explaining your interest. You'll receive an email notification once the team lead accepts or declines your request.

How do I add people to my team?

- Invite up to 9 IBMers to your team by searching for specific IBMers or using the “AI Find Members” option to find teammates.
- To invite a specific IBMer to your team, filter by either their name or email and click the “Invite to team” button next to their name. They will receive an invitation to register and join your team. If they are not already registered for the challenge, they will need to register before accepting.

How can I use AI to find a team?

If you don’t already have a team, go to “AI team match” and enter a prompt sharing your background, skills and interests. You can review suggested teams and request to join from the list of results. New matches will continue to surface as more teams are created, so check back on the site.

How do I leave a team?

Teams may change during the challenge. Participants can select “Leave team” from their team page, and team leads may remove members as needed. A team is disbanded once all members leave. At submission time, teams will have the chance to confirm participating members.

Can participants join multiple teams?

Each participant can only join one team.

Tools, access and restrictions



What tools will I use during the challenge?

- The featured tool for the 2026 IBMer watsonx Challenge is IBM Bob, which is available to IBMers during and following the challenge. You can sign up for Bob [here](#).
- IBM Consulting will use Bob + IBM Consulting Advantage and those who do not have access to Bob will use only IBM Consulting Advantage.
- Further guidance and access instructions for recommended tools will be provided when the challenge begins on July 8 at 10 a.m. ET.

How do I get access to Bob?

You can request access to Bob at [this link](#). Once you've requested access, you will receive an email with installation instructions.

I'm not technical, is Bob really for me?

Yes, IBMers across every area of the business are already seeing meaningful productivity gains with Bob. While Bob was created to support every stage of the software development life cycle, there's real value to be found in applying those principles in how we all work at IBM.

Can I use Bob before the challenge begins?

Yes, IBMers are encouraged to begin using Bob and getting familiar with the tool. You can request access to Bob [here](#).

Can I submit something I created with Bob before the challenge, or during a Bob-a-thon?

IBMers are welcome to take what they have created in Bob and work on advancing it during the challenge. Just remember, what you submit must be original work that was substantially developed during the challenge between July 8 at 10 a.m. ET and July 22 at 10 a.m. ET.

How many Bobcoins do IBMers receive for the challenge?

Eligible Bob users will receive the standard monthly budget of Bobcoins and will be expected to use that for the challenge.

I have questions about using Bob. Where can I go?

Start by asking Bob your question. If Bob isn't able to help, you can check [Bob Docs](#) for tips or visit the [#bob-and-friends](#) community in Slack. Once the challenge begins, further support will be available.

Will tool access continue after the challenge?

Yes. Participants who are granted access to IBM Bob during the challenge will retain access after the challenge concludes. Most other AI productivity tools are already available based on role and area of the business.

Can I use other AI tools as part of the challenge?

Normal usage of IBM-approved AI tools, like Copilot or Box AI, as part of your daily work can continue for the challenge, but your challenge submission must focus on the use of IBM Bob and/or IBM Consulting Advantage.

I'm having technical difficulties, what do I do?

If you're looking for help with Cisco Secure Client VPN, IBM managed devices, IBM supported apps, your operating system, security, IBM Wi-Fi, or other non-challenge related technical issues, visit [AskIT](#).

Bob access restrictions **Why is IBM Bob not available to me?**

If your work location is located in China, Hong Kong, Russia or Venezuela, Bob is not available to you. If this changes, registered challenge participants from the impacted countries will be made aware.

How do I know whether IBM Bob is available in my country?

If your work location is located in China, Hong Kong, Russia or Venezuela, IBM Bob is not available to you. When you request access to Bob you will not be granted access.

Can I still participate in the 2026 IBMer watsonx Challenge if Bob is not available to me?

Yes, IBMers without access to Bob due to product restrictions are still encouraged to participate in the challenge and can do so using IBM Consulting Advantage. More information about how to participate without IBM Bob access will be available when the challenge begins on July 8 at 10 a.m. ET.

Will I be penalized for not using IBM Bob in my submission?

- No, IBMers who do not have access to IBM Bob are fully eligible for prizes and advancement and will not be penalized during judging.
- All submissions will be evaluated against the same judging criteria, regardless of tool usage. Geographic or regulatory limitations on tool

access will be considered to ensure equitable evaluation across all participants.

If I don't have access to IBM Bob, can I join a team with someone who does?

- This year's challenge is about using AI tools for personal and team productivity and applying them to work following the challenge. It is highly encouraged that you use tools that are available to you and team with those with the same level of access.
 - If you do choose to join a team with users who have access to IBM Bob, review IBM BCGs for licensed software usage guidelines and avoid screensharing with non-authorized users.
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More than just a challenge, an IBMer tradition

Now in its 4th iteration, the IBMer watsonx Challenge has grown year after year. Take a look back at how it all started, how it evolved, the moments that shaped it, and what past winners did next.

[Learn more about the challenge →](#)



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